09-02 第1篇

阅读理解（说明文） Why Do We Yawn — and Is It Really "Catching"?

① You are sitting in a late afternoon English class. The window is half open, the blackboard is half full, and the teacher's voice moves slowly like a warm river. Then, somewhere in the back row, a boy **opens his mouth wide and yawns**. Two seconds later, his deskmate yawns too. Three seconds later, the girl in the middle row follows — even though she has had a full night's sleep. Within a minute, half the class is stretching their arms and trying to hide a yawn behind a hand. Why do we yawn at all? And why do yawns seem to **spread** around a room?

② First, let us look at what a yawn actually is. A yawn is a **long, slow, deep breath** that takes in more air than a normal breath. At the same time, the jaw opens wide, the throat stretches, the eyes sometimes water a little, and the ears may feel a small "pop". A yawn usually lasts about **six seconds** from start to finish. Most humans yawn between **5 and 20 times a day**, though some people yawn more often and some much less.

③ Scientists have suggested several reasons for yawning. For many years, a popular idea was that a yawn gives the body **more oxygen** when breathing has become shallow. This answer sounds simple, but new research shows that people yawn **just as much** when they breathe pure oxygen as when they breathe ordinary air. So yawning is probably not only about oxygen.

④ Today, a more widely accepted idea is that **yawning cools the brain**. The brain works best within a narrow temperature range. When we are sleepy, bored, or overheated, the brain warms up a little. Taking a deep yawn pulls in a strong flow of air across the mouth and throat. As blood passes through this area, it is cooled down slightly and then flows on to the brain. In one study, students who held a **warm pack** on their forehead yawned **more** than students who held a **cool pack**. Yawning, in other words, may be a free air conditioner for our busy minds.

⑤ Yawning is also linked to **changes of state**. We often yawn when we are moving from one activity to another: just before bed, just after waking up, before an important exam, or when a boring class is about to end. Animals do the same. Lions yawn before they begin to hunt; cats yawn after they wake up; dogs yawn when they feel nervous at the vet's. A yawn, then, may be a little signal that the body is **shifting gears**.

⑥ Now we come to the most interesting part: **why are yawns "catching"**? When you see — or even read about — someone yawning, you are likely to yawn within a few seconds. Right now, you may already feel a small yawn starting in your throat. This spreading is

called a **contagious yawn**. Research in many countries has shown that contagious yawning is very common in humans, especially among **close friends and family**. It is even found in chimpanzees and some dogs.

⑦ Scientists now believe contagious yawning is not a random accident. It is closely linked to our ability to **feel what others feel**, called **empathy**. When we see a friend yawn, our brain quietly copies the action, a bit like smiling back at someone who smiles at us. Studies have found that we are **most likely** to yawn with our family members, **a bit less likely** to yawn with close friends, and **least likely** to yawn with strangers. People who score higher in empathy tests tend to catch yawns more easily.

⑧ Children under **four years old** seldom catch yawns, because their empathy is still developing. As our social brain grows, so does our yawning habit. In a way, the everyday yawn is a **small social bridge**: we are tuning into each other, even when we are just sleepy.

⑨ So next time you see a classmate yawn in a late afternoon class, don't feel guilty if you yawn too. You are probably doing three small things at the same time: **cooling your brain, preparing to change activity**, and **showing, quietly, that you notice another human being**. That is a lot of work for a breath that lasts only six seconds.

注释： yawn 打哈欠；contagious 有传染性的；empathy 同理心；shift gears 转换状态

根据文章内容，选择最佳答案。

1. About how long does a typical yawn last?

A. About one second.
B. About six seconds.
C. About thirty seconds.
D. About five minutes.

2. Why do scientists no longer believe yawning is mainly about getting more oxygen?

A. Because people stop yawning when they sleep.
B. Because people yawn just as much when they breathe pure oxygen as when they breathe ordinary air.
C. Because oxygen is a very rare gas on Earth.
D. Because no one really yawns anymore.

3. According to the "brain cooling" idea, which group of students yawned more in the study?

A. Students who held a warm pack on their forehead.
B. Students who held a cool pack on their forehead.

C. Students who drank hot water.
D. Students who ate ice cream.

4. Which statement about contagious yawning is NOT supported by the passage?

A. We are most likely to catch yawns from our family members.
B. Contagious yawning is linked to our ability to share others' feelings, called empathy.
C. Children under four years old often catch yawns very easily.
D. Some chimpanzees and dogs can catch yawns too.

5. What is the main purpose of this passage?

A. To show that yawning is a kind of magic.
B. To explain the possible reasons for yawning and for "catching" another person's yawn.
C. To advise us to stop yawning in public.
D. To tell a funny personal story about a class.

答案与解析

1.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第②段 "A yawn usually lasts about six seconds"
【解析】一次哈欠约六秒。其余选项均错。故选 B。

2.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第③段 "people yawn just as much when they breathe pure oxygen as when they breathe ordinary air"
【解析】实验否定了纯氧气假说。A、C、D 均与原文无关。故选 B。

3.
【答案】A
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第④段 "students who held a warm pack on their forehead yawned more"
【解析】额前敷热包的组打哈欠更多，与"降温大脑"一致。B 正好相反。C、D 无依据。故选 A。

4.
【答案】C
【题型】细节判断题（否定型）
【定位】第⑧段 "Children under four years old seldom catch yawns"
【解析】四岁以下的孩子很少被"传染"打哈欠，与 C 表述相反。A、B、D 均有原文依据。故选 C。

5.
【答案】B
【题型】主旨大意题
【定位】全文围绕哈欠的成因及其传染现象
【解析】文章旨在从科学角度解释哈欠及传染哈欠的可能原因。A、C、D 均偏离主题。故选B。